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their political opponents. "Since January 2007, an abnormal situation had developed with an alliance of forces led by Trinamool Congress driving out workers and supporters of the Left Front including elected panchayat members," read a politburo statement. While an independent inquiry might be able to establish the number of deaths in Nandigram since early this year, the politburo claimed that 27 CPI(M) supporters and workers were killed in the past few months.

The party leadership is unapologetic. "If anybody thinks that they can take away Nandigram from us by force, they are wrong," Karat told re-

CAUGHT IN THE CROSSFIRE: The homeless in Nandigram

porters. Although Karat had no proof of Maoist presence in Nandigram, he continued to search for bogeymen. His theory was that Banerjee had hired Maoists to create havoc there. West Bengal home secretary P.R. Roy's denial of Maoist presence did not deter Karat from holding on to his description of the trouble makers. Other Left Front constituents—CPI, RSP and Forward Bloc—are furious with the big brother. West Bengal units of the three parties have already reacted sharply to the political killings. However, their leaders in Delhi are

eager to play safe. "If Nandigram has been troubled for the last many months, is it not obvious that somewhere things weren't right?" asks Bardhan. Yet, on record, the veteran Communist did not hold the chief minister or CPI(M) responsible for the killings.

The politics of silence is stunning. The "socialist" components of the UPA—RJD and the Samaj Party—have proved their worth as friends of the Marxists. Home Minister Shivraj Patil has said nothing on the atrocity so far. Sonia has been silent too. Parliamentary affairs minister P.R. Dasmunshi's "personal view" was that it was "CPI(M)-led state-sponsored massacre". According to Marxist MPs Sitaram Yechury and Basudev Acharya, "At every stage in the past 11 months since the armed hoodlums backed by the Trinamool Congress took over Nandigram, Dasmunshi has been aiding and abetting these forces." They held the minister

RED BRUTALITY

1979: The police and CPI(M) cadres massacred hundreds of East Bengal refugees in a Sunderban island.

1982: CPI(M) cadres burnt to death 17 Ananda Margis in Kolkata fearing loss of their base in a constituency.

2000: At least 11 landless labourers were killed by CPI(M) activists in Birbhum district over land dispute.

2001: CPI(M) activists killed 18 in Midnapore, during a Trinamool Congress-sponsored state bandh.

accountable for allegedly "opposing CRPF deployment".

This probably is mock anger. The CPI(M) leaders have at no stage named the Congress as a mischief maker. Even the statement against Dasmunshi is not an indictment of his party; it is rather a personal attack. Layers of political games between the Congress and the Marxists at the Centre and the state won't succeed in obscuring the truth about Nandigram. It has shown how the Marxist paranoia can kill, maim, burn and displace. And a party that has internalised the Stalinist horror chambers is unlikely to say sorry. ■